Girl in Pieces (Charlie and Riley)

By Kathleen Glasgow

CHARLIE: (Pg 81-82) A girl is born.

Her father loves her. Her mother loves her father.
Her father is sad.
Her father drinks and smokes, rocks and cries.
Into the river, he goes.
The mother becomes a fist.
The girl is alone.
No one likes the girl.
She tries.
But her mouth is mush.
Stupid girl. Angry girl.
Girl finds knife. Girl makes herself small, small, smaller.
World gone.

INTRODUCTION

17-year-old Charlie Davis thinks she has little reason to live: her father drowned himself; her abusive mother kicked her out; and her best friend is nearly brain dead after cutting too deeply.

After spending time in treatment with other young women like herself -- those who find comfort in self-harm -- Charlie is released and takes a bus to Arizona where she finds an apartment, a job and begins to think she might be a "real girl." Pulled in by desire and the feeling of being wanted, she gradually falls for Riley West. But Riley is like her – broken -- and together they fall apart.

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(Intro by 4N6 Fanatics Staff)

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CHARLIE: (Pg 232-233) It's a bad day in the kitchen: Riley has asked me something, and that something is floating in the air between us, becoming heavier and heavier by the second. Riley is staring at me, waiting for me to answer his question.

RILEY: *(hoarsely)* Please. Your shift's almost over. I'll pay you.

CHARLIE: A familiar numbness comes over me as I take off my apron. I don't say anything to Riley. I hold out my hand for the money and close my fingers around it. I slid[e] the money into my pocket. My fingers fish about for a minute, then give up. Riley [doesn't] notice the knife in my pocket . . .

(Pg 233-236) The man who answers the door looks me up and down and then past me, to the street, like he wants to make sure I'm alone. He's chewing on the cap of a pen.

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He asks me what I've got. [I hand him the money.] The man counts the money, reaches back and drops a brown bag [into my hands.] I just turn and leave. I don't stop or look back until I'm pushing through the screen door of True Grit.

Riley pulls me into the grill station, holds out his hands. He tucks the bag under his shirt. He whispers for me to cover the grill for him.

On his way to the bathroom, he motions to the refrigerator. When I open it, I see my thank you: another bulky bag of food. I take it like a robot, no feeling, no expression.

I don't know what to think of what I did or why. I've blanked myself out, erased myself.

[At home], I put the bag of food on the table. I slide the knife from my pocket. And then, just like that, all the numbness I had drops away. Doing that for Riley, it felt ***good***. But I'm getting really far down the ladder of rules, and all of a sudden I'm flooded with despair. I try breathing exercises, but I just gasp, I can't slow down.

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My tender kit is still wedged far back under the claw-foot tub, hidden inside [a] suitcase. I don't want that, I don't. I run the blade of the knife lightly across my forearm, testing. My skin prickles and longing fills me up; my eyes grow wet. I'm so close to feeling better, feeling release, right here, with the stubby little blade. But I turn my arms over, force myself to look at the rough red lines ridging my soft skin. Anything but that. I let the knife clatter to the sink . . .

(Pg 270-275) I forgot to lock the door. When [Riley] knocks, I don't answer, and he pushes in anyway. He's clutching a paper bag and he holds it up to his lips, drinks from it.

I'm between the tub and the wall, where I've been burrowed for the past several hours, waiting. Groaning, he settles on the floor next to me, stretching his legs out on the scarred linoleum. He lolls his head to the side. Something catches his eye and he leans forward.

RILEY: Why do you have a suitcase wedged under the tub, Strange Girl?

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CHARLIE: Before I can stop him, he slides over and pulls it out. He fixes his glisteny eyes on me, the side of his mouth rising in a smile. He lowers his voice in a spooky way.

RILEY: Is this it? Does the magic suitcase hold the secret of my little stranger?

CHARLIE: He flips the clasps and paws through the shirts until he finds the metal kit. Only he thinks it's just something neat, because he says, "Cool." But then he unlatches it. His eyes dart over the objects inside, the creams, the tape, the bandages, everything I bought the first day I got here. My heart's in my throat, watching him.

It's a little mean, a little payback for today, for never asking me about myself. Because it's going to make him scared, and a little sick, being faced with the puzzle pieces of me for a change. Riley picks up the roll of linen hesitantly and lets it unfurl; pieces of broken glass tumble onto the floor, making their family chimelike sound.

RILEY: What the f*** is this?

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CHARLIE: Before I can stop myself, I blurt, "It's me. It's what I do. What I did, I mean. I'm trying not to do that anymore." *(holds her breath, waiting)*

RILEY: *(angry, holding out the box)* What is this?

CHARLIE: He holds up the pieces of glass one by one, the small plastic container of hydrogen peroxide, the tube of ointment, the roll of gauze. *(to Riley)* It's what I use. To cut myself. Those are my things.

(to audience) Riley drops them all back in the box as though they've burned his fingers. He kicks the kit violently across the floor and stands up, yanking the hood of his jacket over his head tightly. I close my eyes. The front door slams.

I crawl across the floor and take my kit in my hands, holding it close to my body. I carefully reassemble everything in its place, because it's all precious to me. In my fingers, the glass tinkles, pricks, tiny promises that I have to steel myself to ignore.

The door to my apartment bangs open.

RILEY: Tell me. Like, what is that all about? Why do you have that box? What does it mean?

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CHARLIE: *(to Riley)* Where did you think my scars came from? Do you think they just . . . appeared by themselves?

RILEY: *(mumbling)* I don't know . . . I just . . . I kind of kept it abstract. I figured you were all done with that. It didn't occur to me that you kept, like, a box of s*** to cut yourself if you [freaking] felt like it.

CHARLIE: *(to Riley, breath coming in gasps)* Are you the only one in the world who gets to be a [screwup]? Am I ***spoiled*** for you now that you've seen my stuff? Did it make me real? *(to audience)* My body is revving up in a dangerous way.

RILEY: *(warning tone)* Don't. Don't even go there.

CHARLIE: *(to Riley)* I'm the only one here who's trying not to do the bad thing, who's trying to get better, and you're treating me like s*** for it.

(to audience) I ferried his drugs. I let him see all of me, every bit, and now I'm sitting here on the grungy floor, a dog at his feet. Like a dog, I wait for him at night. Like a dog, now stupidly, I only want him to pet me, love me,

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not leave, and that makes me suddenly, blazingly angry and sad all at once, which feels like fire inside me.

I pound and claw at his legs. He jumps in surprise. He catches my arms, swearing when I struggle, a flicker of something dark crosses his face, his lip curls. His fingers tighten like metal on my skin. He's shouting now, like my mother . . .

RILEY: What's wrong with you?!? *(raises his hand to strike)*

CHARLIE: And then one of his hands is in the air, fingers together, palm flat. *(she cowers)* My mother and her raised fist flashes in front of my eyes. I shrink away from Riley, shutting myself off, bracing myself.

There is the person people see on the outside and then there is the person on the inside and then, even farther down, is that other buried person, a naked silent creature, not used to light. I have it and now, here, I see it: Riley's hidden person.

RILEY: Jesus, this is [crap]. You're still such a kid. I'm twenty-seven years old. What am I doing?

CHARLIE: His face is papery with exhaustion as he walks to the door. I turn off all the lights and curl up in the

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bathtub in a very tight ball. I imagine myself in an egg, a metal egg, impenetrable, locked on the outside, anything to keep me from crawling to my kit . . .

(Pg 252) I know this is all wrong. But maybe, me being me, this is as good as it's going to get. It's too late anyway . . . I've already fallen in.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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